urea is excreted per day. Various metabolic disorders can affect the composition of urine. Analysis of urine helps in clinical diagnosis of various metabolic disorders and the malfunctioning of the kidneys. For example the presence of glucose (glucosuria) and ketone bodies (ketonuria) in the urine are indications of diabetes mellitus.

8.6 Role of other organs in excretion

Apart from kidneys, organs such as lungs, liver and skin help to remove wastes. Our lungs remove large quantities of carbon dioxide (18 L/day) and significant quantities of water every day. Liver secretes bile containing substances like, bilirubin and biliverdin, cholesterol, steroid hormones, vitamins and drugs which are excreted out along with the digestive wastes.

Sweat and sebaceous glands in the skin eliminate certain wastes through their secretions. Sweat produced by the sweat glands primarily helps to cool the body and secondarily excretes Na^+ and Cl^-, small quantities of urea and lactate. Sebaceous glands eliminate certain substances like sterols, hydrocarbons and waxes through sebum that provides a protective oily covering for the skin. Small quantities of nitrogenous wastes are also excreted through saliva.

8.7 Disorders related to the Excretory System

Urinary tract infection

Female's urethra is very short and its external opening is close to the anal opening, hence improper toilet habits can easily carry faecal bacteria into the urethra. The urethral mucosa is continuous with the urinary tract and the inflammation of the urethra (urethritis) can ascend the tract to cause bladder inflammation (cystitis) or even renal inflammation (pyelitis or pyelonephritis). Symptoms include dysuria (painful urination), urinary urgency, fever and sometimes cloudy or blood tinged urine. When the kidneys are inflammed, back pain and severe headache often occur. Most urinary tract infections can be treated by antibiotics.

Renal Failure (Kidney Failure)

Failure of the kidneys to excrete wastes may lead to accumulation of urea with marked reduction in the urine output. Renal failure are of two types, Acute and chronic renal failure. In acute renal failure the kidney stops its function abruptly, but there are chances for recovery of kidney functions. In chronic renal failure there is a progressive loss of function of the nephrons which gradually decreases the function of kidneys.

Uremia

Uremia is characterized by increase in urea and other non-protein nitrogenous substances like uric acid and creatinine in blood. Normal urea level in human blood is about 17-30mg/100mL of blood. The urea concentration rises as 10 times of normal levels during chronic renal failure.

Renal calculi

Kidney stone or calculi, also called renal stone or nephrolithiasis, is the formation of hard stone like masses in the renal tubules of renal pelvis. It is mainly due to the accumulation of soluble crystals of salts of sodium oxalates and certain phosphates.

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